



VS.talent Design Candidates Report

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Executive Summary

As global footwear and apparel brands continue to accelerate product innovation, international expansion, and organizational transformation, competition for experienced design talent is becoming increasingly strategic. Rather than competing solely within local markets, leading brands are now building globally connected design organizations capable of responding to evolving consumer needs across regions and product categories. Based on **323 footwear and apparel design professionals** who have recently expressed openness to new career opportunities, this report identifies several key trends shaping today's design talent market.

1. Mature brand ecosystems continue to produce the industry's most experienced design talent.

Global brands such as **adidas, Nike, and Puma** remain the primary sources of experienced footwear and apparel designers. Their well-established product creation processes, international collaboration models, and long-term investment in design capabilities continue to cultivate professionals with strong commercial awareness, cross-functional experience, and global product development expertise. Understanding where top talent is developed has become as important as evaluating individual candidates themselves.

2. The global design talent market is becoming increasingly international.

The candidate pool represents a wide range of nationalities and international career backgrounds, reflecting the continued globalization of the footwear and apparel industry. Cross-border talent mobility remains particularly active within **East Asia**, where China, Japan, and Korea continue to strengthen their roles as both major destinations and important sources of global design talent.

3. Regional salary differences continue to shape international hiring strategies.

Compensation levels remain closely aligned with the maturity of regional design ecosystems. While the **United States and Europe** continue to offer the highest salaries for senior design professionals, Asian markets provide access to a growing pool of internationally experienced talent at comparatively competitive compensation levels. As brands expand globally, localized salary benchmarking is becoming increasingly important for attracting and retaining top talent.

4. Hiring priorities are shifting from brand pedigree to capability.

While experience with leading global brands remains highly valued, employers are increasingly focusing on a candidate's ability to drive product innovation, work across multiple categories, collaborate globally, and translate consumer insights into commercially successful products. Capability, adaptability, and international experience are becoming more important indicators of long-term potential than brand background alone.

5. Global talent strategy is becoming a core business capability.

As competition for experienced design professionals intensifies, successful hiring will depend not only on compensation, but also on an organization's ability to build strong employer branding, develop international talent networks, and offer meaningful long-term career opportunities. Companies that combine data-driven talent intelligence with proactive global recruitment strategies will be best positioned to attract, develop, and retain the next generation of design leaders.

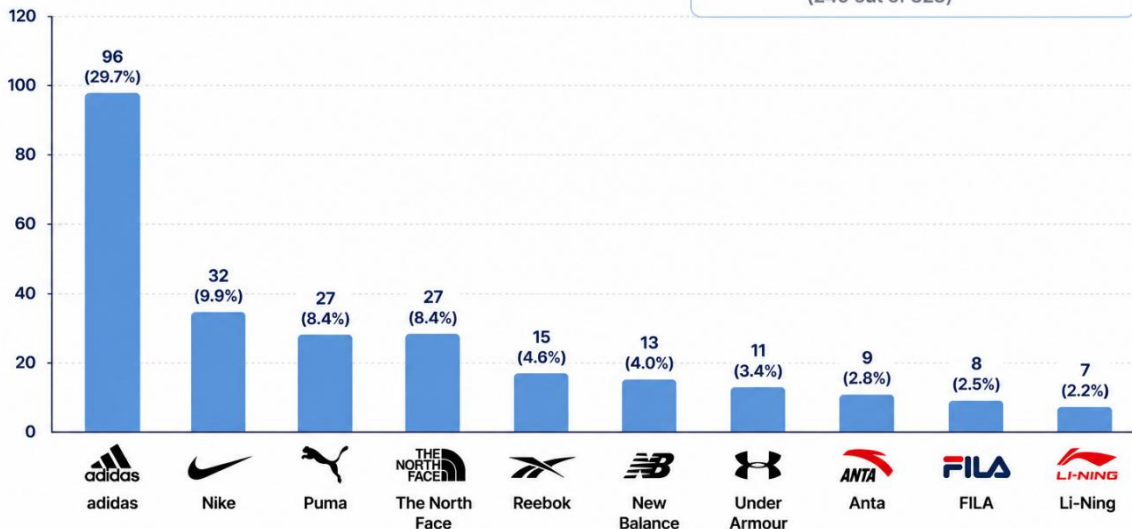
PART I: Talent Analytics

Distribution of Top 10 Brands Served by Candidates:

Distribution of Top 10 Brands Served by Candidates

Total Candidates = 323

Number of Candidates



TOP 10 BRANDS COVER

77.1% OF TOTAL CANDIDATES

(249 out of 323)

Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Data as of June 2026

From the distribution of Top 10 brands served by candidates, several key insights can be drawn:

1. Global design talent remains highly concentrated within a small number of mature brand ecosystems.

The distribution indicates that experienced footwear and apparel designers are not evenly spread across the industry. Instead, they are concentrated within a limited number of globally recognized brands that have established product creation systems, international design platforms, and long-term talent development capabilities.

Implication for Employers

Brands seeking experienced design professionals should prioritize these mature talent ecosystems rather than adopting a broad, unfocused sourcing strategy. Targeted talent mapping within leading organizations is likely to produce stronger hiring outcomes.

2. Leading global brands continue to shape the industry's talent pipeline.

Brands such as adidas, Nike, and Puma continue to produce a significant proportion of experienced design professionals across Footwear, Apparel, Graphic, Accessories, and CMF Design. Their continued prominence reflects years of investment in design capability, product innovation, and international product creation.

Implication for Employers

Candidates from these organizations often bring structured product development methodologies and cross-functional collaboration experience, making them attractive hires for brands building or upgrading design teams.

3. Category-specialist brands are becoming increasingly important talent suppliers.

Beyond the industry's largest brands, companies with strong positions in Outdoor, Performance, and Sportstyle continue to develop highly specialized design talent. This demonstrates that category expertise has become an increasingly valuable differentiator, particularly as consumers expect products that combine technical performance with lifestyle appeal.

Implication for Employers

Brands recruiting for Outdoor, Golf, Running, or Performance categories should evaluate talent based on category expertise rather than overall brand reputation alone.

4. The global design talent ecosystem is becoming more diversified.

Although international brands continue to dominate the talent landscape, regional brands are gradually strengthening their presence through continued investment in product innovation and design capabilities.

This reflects a broader shift in which design talent is being developed across a wider range of organizations than in previous years.

Implication for Employers

Expanding talent searches beyond traditional global brands can uncover experienced designers with strong commercial capabilities and fresh market perspectives.

5. Competition for experienced designers remains concentrated.

The concentration of talent among relatively few organizations means that brands are increasingly competing for the same experienced candidate pool.

As demand for senior designers continues to grow, attracting top talent requires more than competitive compensation.

Implication for Employers

A compelling employer value proposition—including creative autonomy, product influence, international exposure, leadership quality, and long-term career development—is becoming a key differentiator in securing high-quality design talent.

Key Insight

Rather than being evenly distributed across the market, experienced footwear and apparel design talent continues to be concentrated within a relatively small number of mature brand ecosystems. For employers, understanding where talent is developed is becoming just as important as evaluating the talent itself. Brands that combine targeted

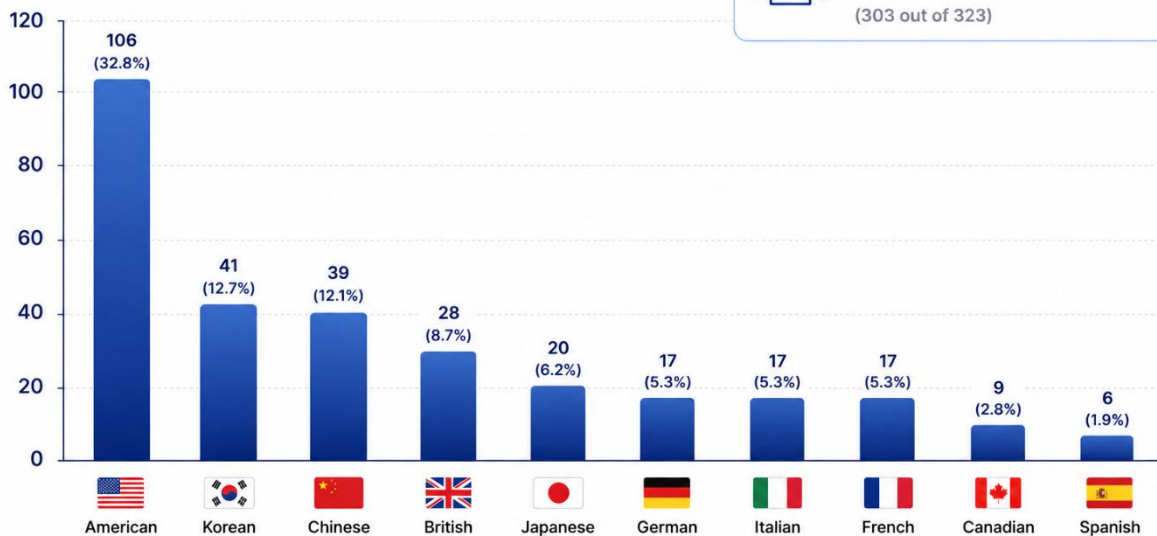
talent mapping with a strong employer value proposition will be better positioned to attract the industry's most sought-after design professionals.

Top 10 Distribution of Nationalities:

Top 10 Distribution of Nationalities

Total Candidates = 323

Number of Candidates



Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Data as of June 2026

From the distribution of nationalities, several valuable insights can be drawn:

1. The global design talent pool remains highly international.

The nationality distribution demonstrates that experienced footwear and apparel designers come from a wide range of countries rather than a single dominant market. This diversity reflects the increasingly global nature of the design profession and the growing demand for multicultural perspectives in product creation.

Implication for Employers

Brands that expand their talent search beyond domestic markets are more likely to access broader creative capabilities, diverse consumer insights, and international product development experience.

2. North America, East Asia, and Europe continue to form the industry's three major talent ecosystems.

The strongest representation of candidates comes from North America, East Asia, and Europe, highlighting these regions as the primary sources of experienced footwear and

apparel design professionals. Each ecosystem has developed distinct strengths through mature brand infrastructures and long-established design cultures.

Implication for Employers

Understanding the characteristics of each regional talent ecosystem enables brands to develop more targeted recruitment strategies based on product category, consumer market, and organizational needs.

3. East Asia has become one of the most active global design talent hubs.

The strong presence of designers from China, South Korea, and Japan reflects the region's growing importance in global product creation. As international brands continue to expand their design operations across East Asia, the region is becoming both a major destination for global talent and an increasingly important source of experienced designers.

Implication for Employers

Brands recruiting within East Asia have access to a deep and internationally experienced talent pool, particularly in Performance, Outdoor, Sportstyle, and Lifestyle product categories.

4. International experience is becoming a defining characteristic of senior design talent.

Many candidates possess multicultural working backgrounds and have contributed to products across multiple countries and regions. Cross-border career paths are becoming increasingly common among experienced designers, reflecting the globalization of product development.

Implication for Employers

Candidates with international experience often adapt more quickly to global teams, cross-functional collaboration, and multi-market product creation, making them valuable assets for brands pursuing international growth.

5. Global competition for design talent continues to intensify.

The diversity of nationalities represented within the candidate pool demonstrates that leading brands are competing for talent on a global scale rather than within individual domestic markets. As organizations continue to internationalize their design capabilities, attracting top talent requires more than competitive compensation.

Implication for Employers

Building a compelling employer value proposition—including creative autonomy, international exposure, career development opportunities, and strong design leadership—is becoming increasingly important for attracting high-caliber global design talent.

Key Insight

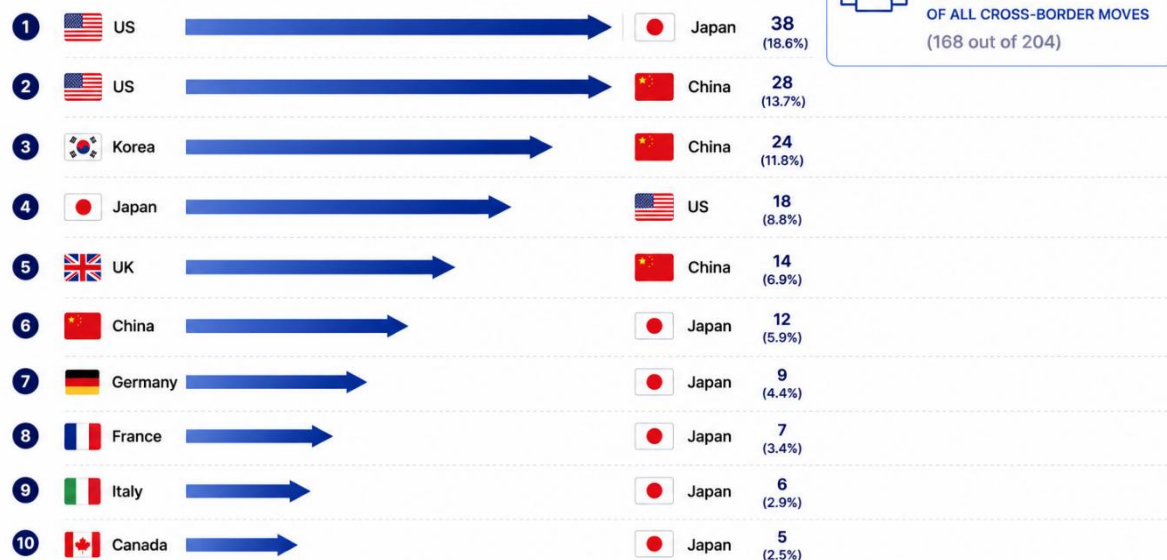
The nationality distribution highlights that today's footwear and apparel design talent market is fundamentally global. Rather than relying on a single geographic talent source, leading brands are increasingly drawing expertise from multiple mature talent ecosystems. Employers that adopt a global recruitment strategy and embrace diverse design perspectives will be better positioned to strengthen innovation, accelerate product development, and build internationally competitive design teams.

Top 10 Cross-Border Talent Flows Chart

Top 10 Cross-border Talent Flows

Total Cross-border Moves = 204

Number of Candidates



Source: VS.talent Candidate Database | Data as of June 2026

Insights from the Top 10 Cross-border Talent Flows Chart:

1. East Asia has become the most active hub for global design talent mobility.

The strongest cross-border talent movements are concentrated between China, Japan, and Korea, highlighting East Asia's growing importance in the global footwear and apparel design ecosystem. As more international brands expand their design operations across the region, talent mobility continues to accelerate.

Implication for Employers

Brands with hiring needs in East Asia can access a highly active international talent market, making regional recruitment an increasingly effective strategy for acquiring experienced design professionals.

2. China continues to strengthen its position as a preferred destination for international design talent.

Cross-border flows indicate that China remains one of the most attractive markets for experienced footwear and apparel designers. The rapid growth of domestic brands, increased investment in design capabilities, and expanding global ambitions continue to attract talent from multiple regions.

Implication for Employers

Employers in China have a growing opportunity to recruit internationally experienced designers, particularly those with expertise in Performance, Outdoor, Sportstyle, and Lifestyle product categories.

3. Japan serves as both a talent exporter and an international talent destination.

Japan remains one of the industry's most mature design ecosystems, with experienced designers seeking opportunities abroad while continuing to attract international professionals. This two-way movement reinforces Japan's strategic role within the regional talent network.

Implication for Employers

Understanding Japan's dual role can help brands develop more targeted recruitment strategies, whether sourcing Japanese talent for overseas roles or attracting international designers into Japan-based teams.

4. Cross-border mobility is increasingly driven by regional opportunities.

Most talent movements occur between geographically connected markets rather than across distant regions. Shared consumer preferences, cultural familiarity, and established industry networks continue to influence designers' relocation decisions.

Implication for Employers

Regional recruitment strategies can often deliver higher-quality talent matches while improving hiring efficiency and increasing the likelihood of successful long-term retention.

5. International mobility is becoming a defining characteristic of senior design talent.

Many experienced designers are open to pursuing opportunities across multiple countries, reflecting the increasingly global nature of footwear and apparel product development. Cross-border experience has become a valuable differentiator for senior-level talent.

Implication for Employers

Candidates with international career paths often bring broader market perspectives, stronger cross-cultural collaboration skills, and greater adaptability, making them valuable contributors to globally oriented design organizations.

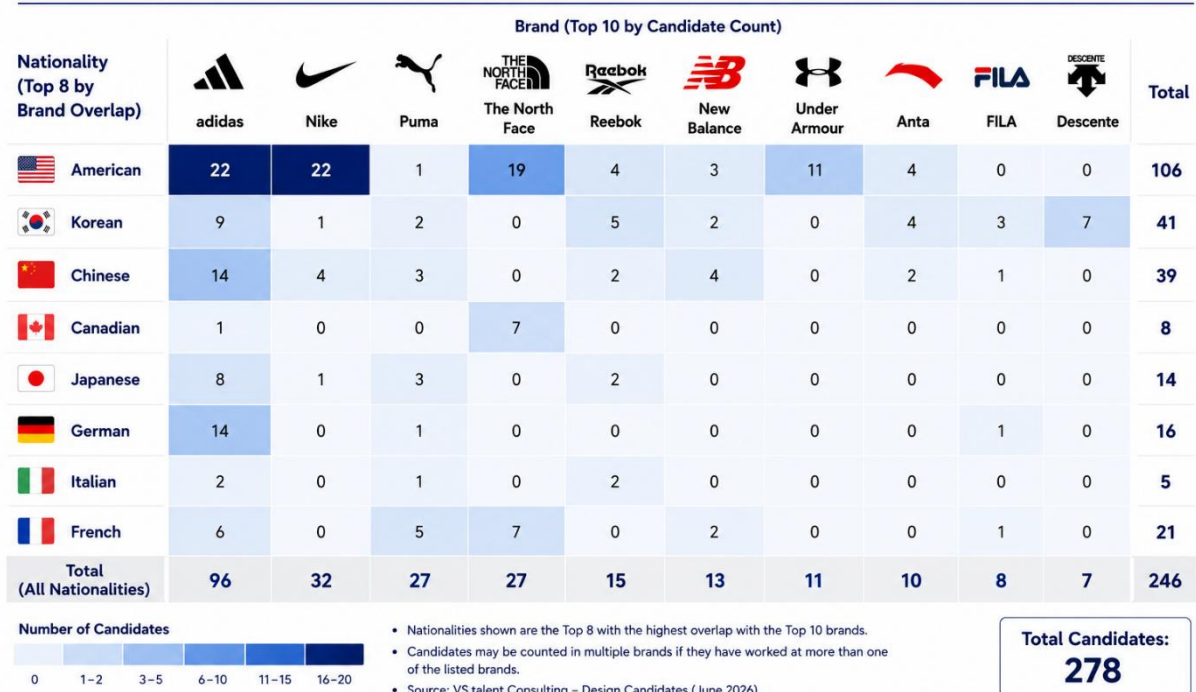
Key Insight

The cross-border talent flow patterns demonstrate that the global footwear and apparel design talent market is becoming increasingly interconnected. East Asia—particularly China and Japan—has emerged as a central hub for international design talent mobility. Brands that embrace cross-border recruitment and leverage international talent networks will be better positioned to strengthen innovation capabilities, accelerate product development, and build globally competitive design teams.

Nationality and Brand Association Heatmap:

Nationality and Top 10 Brands Served by Candidates Association Heatmap

Unit: Number of Candidates | Total Candidates (All Nationalities): 278



Nationality and Brand Association Heatmap provides several key insights:

1. adidas remains the industry's largest global design talent ecosystem.

The heatmap shows that **adidas** has the broadest nationality representation among all leading brands, demonstrating its role as the industry's largest incubator of footwear and apparel design talent. Its global design organization continues to attract and develop designers across multiple regions, functions, and product categories.

Implication for Employers

Brands seeking experienced and internationally exposed design talent should regard adidas as one of the most valuable sourcing ecosystems, particularly for leadership and cross-functional design roles.

2. Puma demonstrates one of the most internationally diverse talent compositions.

Compared with many global brands, **Puma** is associated with designers from a remarkably wide range of nationalities. This indicates a highly international design organization where designers from different cultural backgrounds collaborate across product categories and global markets.

Implication for Employers

Candidates with Puma backgrounds often possess strong cross-cultural collaboration experience and adaptability, making them particularly suitable for brands operating across multiple international markets.

3. Nike continues to cultivate some of the industry's most influential design talent.

Although Nike's nationality distribution is less diversified than Puma's, its talent pool remains one of the most influential in the industry. Nike designers are widely recognized for their expertise in Performance innovation, consumer-centered design, and product storytelling, making them consistently attractive across the global market.

Implication for Employers

Nike-background candidates are particularly valuable for brands seeking innovation capability, performance product expertise, and strong consumer-driven design thinking.

4. East Asia has become a major contributor to the global design talent ecosystem.

Chinese, Japanese, and Korean designers are widely represented across leading international brands, highlighting East Asia's growing importance in global footwear and apparel design. The region has evolved beyond being a manufacturing base to become a key source of internationally competitive design talent.

Implication for Employers

Brands expanding in Asia can benefit from accessing a mature regional talent ecosystem that combines international brand experience with strong local market understanding.

5. Brand ecosystems are becoming more important than geography in talent development.

Rather than developing within isolated national markets, experienced designers increasingly build their careers inside globally connected brand ecosystems. International brands have become platforms where talent acquires cross-cultural experience, global product knowledge, and international collaboration capabilities.

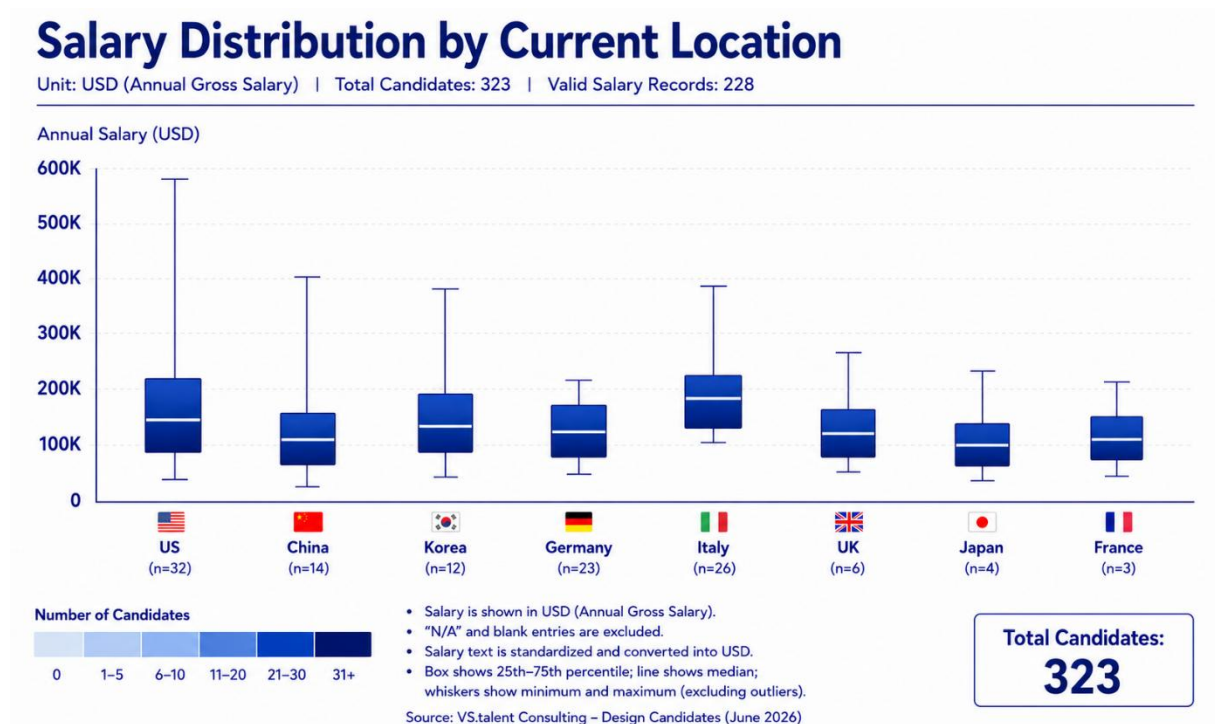
Implication for Employers

Understanding which brand ecosystems consistently produce high-performing designers can significantly improve sourcing efficiency and help identify candidates with broader global perspectives.

Key Insight

The Association Heatmap demonstrates that the global footwear and apparel design talent market is increasingly shaped by a small number of internationally connected brand ecosystems. While **adidas** remains the industry's largest global talent incubator, **Puma** stands out for its internationally diverse talent composition, and **Nike** continues to produce highly influential design professionals. For employers, understanding the relationship between nationality and brand background provides deeper insight into where globally competitive design talent is developed and how to build more effective international recruitment strategies.

Salary Distribution By Current Location:



Insights from the Salary Distribution by Current Location Boxplot:

1. The US and Europe continue to lead in senior design compensation.

The **US** remains the highest-paying market, with both the highest median salary and the widest salary range, while **Germany** and **Italy** also demonstrate strong compensation levels. These mature design markets are home to many global sportswear, outdoor, and luxury fashion headquarters, creating sustained demand for highly experienced design leaders.

Implication for Employers:

Brands competing for senior design talent in the US and Europe should expect significantly higher compensation expectations. For international hiring, employers need to balance salary competitiveness with broader value propositions such as global responsibilities, career development, and relocation support.

2. Asian markets offer competitive talent with more cost-efficient salary structures.

Compared with Western markets, **China, Korea, and Japan** generally exhibit lower overall salary levels, although notable differences exist within the region. Korea maintains relatively strong compensation for experienced designers, while China offers a broader salary distribution driven by its diverse mix of local brands, international companies, and rapidly expanding design organizations. Japan shows the most standardized salary structure with relatively limited variation.

Implication for Employers:

Asia continues to provide access to high-quality design talent at comparatively competitive compensation levels, making the region an attractive option for brands seeking to expand global design teams while maintaining cost efficiency.

3. Salary dispersion reflects differences in market maturity and talent hierarchy.

Markets such as the **US, Germany, and Italy** display wider salary ranges, indicating clear differentiation between mid-level and executive design positions. In contrast, Asian markets generally show narrower salary distributions, suggesting more standardized compensation structures and fewer extreme salary outliers.

Implication for Employers:

When benchmarking salaries across regions, employers should evaluate not only median compensation but also salary dispersion, as it provides valuable insight into market maturity, organizational hierarchy, and the availability of senior leadership talent.

Key Insight

Global salary differences continue to reflect regional market maturity, brand concentration, and talent scarcity. While Western markets remain the benchmark for senior design compensation, Asia has become an increasingly attractive destination by combining a growing pool of experienced design talent with relatively competitive salary levels, enabling brands to build high-performing global design organizations more efficiently.

PART II Market Watch

From Brand Prestige to Capability Advantage: How Hiring Priorities Are Evolving in Footwear and Apparel Design

For many years, recruitment within the footwear and apparel industry has largely been shaped by brand reputation. Designers from globally recognized companies such as Nike, adidas, Puma, and other leading organizations have traditionally enjoyed a significant advantage in the talent market, as employers often viewed brand pedigree as a reliable indicator of design capability.

Today, however, this hiring logic is beginning to change.

As product innovation accelerates and category boundaries continue to blur, employers are placing greater emphasis on **what designers are capable of delivering**, rather than simply where they have worked. Experience in building commercially successful product stories, leading cross-functional collaboration, managing complete product creation processes, and responding quickly to changing consumer trends is becoming increasingly valuable. Brand background remains important, but it is no longer the sole measure of a candidate's competitiveness.

This shift is particularly evident in the growing demand for designers with cross-category experience. Professionals who have worked across Performance, Outdoor, Sportstyle, Golf, and Lifestyle categories are increasingly viewed as more adaptable to rapidly changing market needs than those with highly specialized backgrounds. Likewise, designers who have participated in global product creation, collaborated with international teams, or successfully translated consumer insights into commercially successful collections are becoming highly sought after across both international and domestic brands.

At the same time, many emerging brands are broadening their hiring strategies. Rather than focusing exclusively on candidates from a handful of global industry leaders, companies are increasingly identifying transferable capabilities across a wider range of organizations. Designers from niche outdoor brands, premium fashion labels, specialist performance companies, and fast-growing local brands are receiving greater attention, provided they can demonstrate strong product thinking, consumer understanding, and commercial execution.

For employers, this evolution presents both opportunities and challenges. Access to a broader talent pool enables companies to recruit beyond traditional brand ecosystems, but it also requires more sophisticated assessment methods. Portfolio quality, problem-solving ability, product strategy, cross-functional collaboration, and leadership potential are becoming as important as previous employer names. Organizations that adopt capability-based hiring rather than relying primarily on brand reputation will be better positioned to identify high-potential talent in an increasingly competitive market.

PART III: Featured Candidates

	Function	Nationality	Brand Served	Category	Preferred Location	Current Salary (USD)
1	Apparel Design	Korean	Vans	Sportstyle	Japan, China, Korea	200K
2	Apparel Design	British	adidas	Sportstyle	China, Japan, Korea	140K
3	Footwear Design	American	Under Armour	Basketball, Running	US	258K
4	Footwear Design	Korean	K2, Descente	Running, Outdoor	Korea, China	N/A
5	Apparel Design	Chinese	Puma	Sportstyle	China	115K
6	Footwear Design	American	Nike	Sportstyle	Japan, US	N/A
7	Apparel Design	Italian	Moncler	Luxury	Remote Work	395K
8	Apparel Design	Canadian	Arc'teryx	Outdoor	Japan	N/A
9	Apparel Design	German	adidas	Outdoor, Fashion	China	N/A
10	Footwear Design	American	Reebok, Under Armour	Performance	US, remote working	300K

11	Apparel Design	Korean	The North Face, New Balance	Outdoor, Performance	Japan	57K
12	Apparel Design	Japanese	Michael Kors	Fashion	US, Remote work	N/A
13	Apparel Design	American	The North Face	Outdoor	US, Remote work	N/A
14	Apparel Design	Korean	The North Face	Outdoor	Korea, Japan	78K
15	Accessory Design	Chinese	adidas	Sportstyle	China	N/A
16	Apparel Design	British	Stella McCartney	Sportstyle	China	374K
17	Footwear Design	American	adidas, Anta	Sportstyle	China	N/A
18	Apparel Design	American	adidas	Sportstyle	Japan, China, US	240K
19	Technical Design	American	The North Face	Outdoor	Japan	124K
20	Apparel Design	Indian	adidas	Performance	Korea, Japan	N/A
21	Apparel Design	Swedish	HOUDINI	Outdoor	Europe	N/A

22	Footwear Design	German	adidas	Outdoor	Germany	N/A
23	Apparel Design	Japanese	Arc'teryx	Outdoor	Japan	240K
24	CMF Design	British	adidas	Performance	China	N/A
25	Apparel Design	German	adidas	Outdoor	Japan	N/A
26	Apparel Design	Chinese	adidas, Reebok	Performance	China	N/A
27	Apparel Design	Japanese	ASICS	Performance	Japan, China, Europe	N/A
28	Apparel Design	British	adidas	Outdoor	Japan	240K
29	Apparel Design	British	LVMH	Luxury	China	260K
30	Apparel Design	American	Tory Burch	Luxury	China	600K

PART IV: Hiring Recommendations

1. Build talent pipelines around proven design ecosystems rather than individual brands.

The data shows that experienced design talent remains highly concentrated within a relatively small group of global brands, particularly **adidas, Nike, Puma, New Balance, and Anta**. These organizations continue to serve as the industry's primary talent incubators, producing designers with strong product creation capabilities and cross-functional collaboration experience.

Recommendation:

Rather than relying on opportunistic hiring, brands should establish long-term talent pipelines targeting these mature design ecosystems, where candidates are more likely to possess scalable design processes, commercial awareness, and international product development experience.

2. Expand recruitment beyond local markets to access broader regional talent pools.

The cross-border talent flow analysis suggests that East Asia has become one of the most active regions for international designer mobility. Many experienced designers are increasingly open to opportunities across **China, Japan, Korea, and Southeast Asia**, indicating that geographic flexibility has become a key characteristic of today's design talent market.

Recommendation:

Brands should broaden their search beyond domestic candidates and adopt regional recruitment strategies, particularly for senior and niche design functions where local talent availability may be limited.

3. Differentiate employer value propositions by regional talent expectations.

Salary benchmarking demonstrates significant differences across major markets. While Western markets continue to command premium compensation for senior talent, Asian markets provide access to high-quality designers at relatively competitive salary levels. However, compensation alone is rarely the deciding factor for experienced designers.

Recommendation:

To improve hiring success, employers should tailor their employer value proposition according to regional market expectations by combining competitive compensation with clear career progression, international exposure, creative autonomy, and flexible working arrangements.

4. Prioritize internationally experienced designers for global product strategies.

A growing proportion of candidates possess experience across multiple countries, brands, and product categories. These designers are increasingly valuable as brands pursue

global expansion and seek stronger alignment between regional consumer insights and global product strategies.

Recommendation:

When hiring for leadership or strategic design roles, international experience should be treated as a core evaluation criterion alongside technical capability and portfolio quality, particularly for brands building globally integrated design organizations.

Key Recommendation

As competition for experienced footwear and apparel designers continues to intensify, successful hiring will increasingly depend on a brand's ability to identify the right talent ecosystems, recruit across borders, and offer compelling long-term career opportunities. Organizations that combine data-driven talent intelligence with proactive global sourcing strategies will be better positioned to secure the next generation of design leaders.

About the Cover Page

Paris Street; Rainy Day is one of the most renowned works by French artist Gustave Caillebotte, created in 1877 and widely recognized as a masterpiece capturing the spirit of modern urban life. Set in the newly transformed streets of 19th-century Paris, the painting portrays elegantly dressed figures moving through a rainy city landscape, where architecture, movement, and atmosphere come together in quiet harmony. Through its distinctive perspective, photographic composition, and subtle grey-blue palette, Caillebotte presents a moment of everyday life with remarkable depth and sophistication. The work reflects not only the elegance of Parisian society but also the changing relationship between people and the modern city, making it a timeless symbol of transition, movement, and urban identity.

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